

Chapter 35-1: Illusion

"Master!?" Qiu Yi, sitting on the platform, jumped up, unable to believe her eyes.

"How did the Divine Venerable enter? Has this Nightmare Beast gone mad?"

"Where? Where?" Disciples kept standing on their tiptoes to see. The already crowded platform became even more chaotic, with disciples sitting in the back rows who couldn't see clearly even surging forward like a swarm, and even the sect leaders stretched their necks to look.

It wasn't until the white-bearded old man spoke to stabilize the situation that some order was restored.

"Everyone please remain calm. Since you have all entered the illusion, there's no way out. Please sit properly and don't push!" The white-bearded old man hurriedly called out, gesturing with both hands for everyone to be quiet, then looked at the arched door with equal amazement.

Of course, the most incredulous were those from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. The disciples were so surprised they couldn't speak, several elders looked at each other in confusion, and Mei Chengsi gripped his tea cup with furrowed brows.

"I also think this Nightmare Beast made a mistake. Who doesn't know that Chu Ling Divine Venerable cultivates the Path of Emotionlessness¹, and she never concerns herself with worldly affairs. Even though she recently became the leader of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate and came down from Purple Cloud Peak, she normally never leaves the Tranquil Mountain Palace². How could she have any connection with Ning Fuyi?" Elder Jingshan opened his mouth for a long while before finally speaking.

Elder Pingyao didn't speak but took off a string of prayer beads and rolled them in his hands, as if trying to calm himself down.

Elder Yuanming's eyes flashed with amusement as he looked toward Mei Chengsi, who had remained silent the entire time.

"I'll go communicate with the Zhaoyang Saintess. Selecting a disciple with the lowest cultivation was already embarrassing enough, and now having a sect leader participate in such antics - what kind of propriety is this!" Elder Jingshan stood up to leave but was blocked by Elder Yuanming's fan against his body.

"Elder Jingshan, don't be hasty. This competition is just for entertainment. Surely people won't take the results seriously, and anyone with eyes can see that this Nightmare Beast made an error. After all, it's Chu Ling Divine Venerable who entered - no one would dare speak carelessly." Elder Yuanming said with a smile, using his fan to press Elder Jingshan back down.

"But..."

"Since we've come to Zhaoyang Mountain, we must follow the Zhaoyang Saintess's wishes. With thousands of people watching, it would be inappropriate to back out now." Elder Yuanming continued, his smiling voice seeming to soothe people's hearts. "Besides, once the Zhaoyang Conference begins, who will remember today's little episode?"

"What do Sect Leader Mei and Elder Pingyao think?" Elder Yuanming turned to the two who had remained silent.

Mei Chengsi said nothing with a dark expression, only slightly raising his chin to indicate agreement, while Elder Pingyao also sighed and slammed the prayer beads in his hand onto the table.

The high platform buzzed with discussion, while inside the illusion it was completely quiet. Chu Qingqiu immediately understood what had happened and gazed at Ning Fuyi, both falling into contemplation.

There was a faint point of light overhead that allowed them to see each other, but not clearly.

Fortunately, it was dark enough here to hide the embarrassment in Chu Qingqiu's eyes. She simply waved her hand and calmly splashed away the tea.

"How could it be..." Ning Fuyi began to speak, then understanding halfway through, closed her mouth again.

It must be because of the marriage contract. She turned her back, pretending to observe their surroundings.

What was there to compete about in this contest? The one who entered was Chu Qingqiu. Ning Fuyi helplessly closed her eyes. No matter how powerful this Nightmare Beast's magic was, it probably couldn't withstand even a wave of Chu Qingqiu's sleeve.

She wondered what the people outside thought when they saw that she had somehow brought Chu Qingqiu in with her.

The Nightmare Beast hadn't appeared yet, and the atmosphere was silent. To ease the awkwardness, Ning Fuyi tried to make conversation: "Divine Venerable, yesterday..."

"It's fine now. Just don't mention my injury to anyone." Chu Qingqiu stood calmly where she was, looking down.

"Don't worry." Ning Fuyi laughed it off but didn't ask more questions. Then she probed: "Did I do anything yesterday?"

Chu Qingqiu paused, her lips moving in the darkness before she spoke: "No."

That was good. Ning Fuyi breathed another sigh of relief and touched the bruise still remaining on the back of her head.

Suddenly, an old man's hoarse voice came from the void. The voice was very soft, but very clear to hear. Ning Fuyi immediately put aside all other thoughts.

"What is fear? That which tears at the heart and cannot be forgotten. All things return to their roots. Returning to the root is called stillness, this is called returning to destiny³."

"Return, return."

As the last words fell, the darkness before them suddenly lifted, like day and night alternating and yin and yang intersecting. Blinding light poured down from above. Ning Fuyi was instantly forced to close her eyes, and when she opened them again, she stood frozen in place.

She found herself standing in a familiar great hall, with the smell of blood permeating the air. A woman who usually wore a smile was now half-kneeling on the ground, one hand supporting herself on a sword hilt, the other covering her chest, with fresh blood continuously flowing from the corners of her mouth.

"Ning Changfeng..." Ning Fuyi murmured.

This was the day when Ning Changfeng's immortal meridians were completely severed and her heart split, dying before Ning Fuyi's eyes.

Enormous grief and helplessness quickly enveloped her. The long-forgotten sorrow crashed into her mind, and she seemed to instantly become that young girl who could only watch her mother die helplessly, her heart and lungs feeling like they were churning, with intense nausea making her very dizzy.

Ning Fuyi broke out in a cold sweat. She stood frozen in place, watching as Ning Changfeng's delicate face was gradually submerged by blood flowing from her seven orifices⁴.

"Ning, Ning Fuyi, come here." Ning Changfeng was reaching out to call her, her face contorted with pain. Ning Fuyi moved her stiff body and slowly approached, half-crouching down.

Her voice was like bubbling air, unable to say anything clearly, so she grasped Ning Fuyi's hand and wrote a character in her palm.

The feeling of grief still consumed her mind. Ning Fuyi endured the urge to vomit and reached out to touch Ning Changfeng's body, but was suddenly pulled up by someone. A figure identical to herself crashed into her view.

The young girl was crying, sobbing heartbrokenly, her expression so painful it was almost unrecognizable, the two familiar tear moles under her eyes red and black.

"What should I do?" she was crying out, blood also flowing from the corners of her mouth. "What should I do? She's dead, what do I do?"

Her feelings seemed to transmit to Ning Fuyi. Ning Fuyi suddenly felt severe pain in her heart and lungs, her mind becoming hazy, merging with the grief-stricken young girl before her, as if she was about to become her.

"Stay with me, I'm so scared alone." The young girl was extremely pitiful. She suddenly reached out to grasp Ning Fuyi's hand. "Please, protect me."

Ning Fuyi's vision was chaotic, her perspective sometimes becoming the young girl's, sometimes returning to her own.

"Alright." Ning Fuyi said.

However, the moment the young girl smiled, her previously clenched fist suddenly opened, revealing a dagger materialized from immortal power in her palm. In the next instant, it carried a glimmering light and pierced into the young girl's chest.

A scream that almost pierced the eardrums echoed in her mind, making her head ache terribly. Ning Fuyi frowned and slightly shrank her head.

But in an instant, the screaming stopped abruptly, and everything around fell into silence. Ning Fuyi also suddenly opened her eyes, with darkness falling on her shoulders, quiet to the point of being uncomfortable.

The painful feelings in her body also disappeared with the screaming, leaving only a body covered in sweat.

Author's Note: [1] Quote from the Dao De Jing

Footnotes:

1. **Path of Emotionlessness (无情道)** - A cultivation path that requires the practitioner to abandon all emotions and attachments to achieve immortality
2. **Tranquil Mountain Palace (静山宫)** - Chu Qingqiu's residence where she practices in seclusion
3. **Quote from Dao De Jing** - This is a reference to Chapter 16 of the Dao De Jing (Tao Te Ching), a fundamental text of Daoist philosophy
4. **Seven orifices (七窍)** - The seven openings in the head: two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, and the mouth